The Last Rung on the Ladder

By Stephen King

LARRY: **(Pg 279-290)** I've been awake all night with it, with Katrina's letter. She could have put it on a postcard. There was only a single sentence below the "Dear Larry." But a sentence can mean enough. It can do enough.

We grew up eighty miles west of Omaha in a town called Hemingford Home-my dad, my mom, my sister Katrina, and me. I was two years older than Katrina, whom everyone called Kitty. She was a beautiful child even at eight, the year of the incident in the barn. It's her I want to tell you about.

INTRODUCTION

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LARRY: It happened one Saturday in early November. Mom was at a bake fair in Columbia City, and Dad had gone over to our nearest neighbor's (seven miles away) Dad left me a list of chores to do and told us not to get to playing until they were all done. But that wasn't long.

I remember that day very clearly. The sky was overcast and while it wasn't cold, you could feel it wanting to be cold. On a day like that, the only really nice place to be was the barn. It was warm and filled with a pleasant mixed aroma of hay and fur.

There was a ladder nailed to a crossbeam high up in the third loft, a ladder that went straight down to the main bam floor. We were forbidden to climb on it because it was old and shaky. Dad had promised Mom a thousand times that he would pull it down and put up a stronger one, but something else always seemed to come up.

If you climbed up that rickety ladder-there were exactly forty-three rungs, Kitty and I had counted them enough to know-you ended up on a beam that was seventy feet above the

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straw-littered bam floor. And then if you edged out along the beam about twelve feet, your knees jittering, your ankle joints creaking, your mouth dry, you stood over the haymow. And then you could jump off the beam and fall seventy feet straight down, with a horrible hilarious dying swoop, into a huge soft bed of hay.

It was a forbidden sport, all right. If we had been caught, my mother would have shrieked blue murder and my father would have laid on the strap. Because of the ladder, and because if you happened to lose your balance and toppled from the beam before you had edged out over the loose fathoms of hay, you would fall to utter destruction on the hard planking of the barn floor.

But the temptation was just too great. When the cats are away . . . well, you know how that one goes.

That day started like all the others, a delicious feeling of dread mixed with anticipation. We stood at the foot of the ladder, looking at each other. Kitty's color was high, her eyes darker and more sparkling than ever. *(to Kitty)* Dare you.

KITTY: Dares go first.

LARRY: Girls go before boys.

KITTY: Not if it's dangerous.

LARRY: I was ten that year, and thin as Scratch-the demon, almost ninety pounds. Kitty was eight and twenty pounds lighter. The ladder had always held us before.

I could feel it that day, beginning to shimmy around a little bit in the dusty barn air as I climbed higher and higher. As always, about halfway up I entertained a vision of what would happen to me if it suddenly let go. But I kept climbing until I was able to clap my hands around the beam and boost myself up and look down.

Kitty's face, turned up to watch me, was a small white oval. In her faded checked shirt and blue denims, she looked like a doll. *(to Kitty)* Hi. down there!

KITTY: Hi. up there!

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LARRY: I stood up. Swayed back and forth a little. I could hear my own heartbeat as I began to inch along with my arms held out for balance. At last, I stood above the safety of the hay. There was a moment of anticipation. Then I stepped off into space, and as it always did, the sudden grip of gravity, yanking me down, making me plummet, made me feel like yelling: Oh, I'm sorry, I made a mistake, let me back upl

Then I hit the hay, sort of swimming through it, until I could climb out onto the barn floor. I had hay down my pants and down the back of my shirt.

She was halfway up the ladder by then, her gold pigtails bouncing against her shoulder blades. I remember thinking that I didn't like the way the ladder was swaying back and forth. Then she was on the beam,

She stood, poising on the toes of her old low-topped Keds, hands out in front of her. And then she swanned. Talk about things you can't forget, things you can't describe. For a moment she seemed to hang in the air. She was Kitty, my sister, her arms swept behind her and her back arched, and how I loved her for that beat of time.

Then she came down and plowed into the hay and out of sight. An explosion of chaff and giggles rose out of the hole she made. I'd forgotten about how rickety the ladder had looked with her on it, and by the time she was out, I was halfway up again.

I felt the ladder moving beneath me and I could hear-very faintly-the whining rasp of old nails loosening up in the wood. And for the first time I was really, actively scared. I think if I'd been closer to the bottom I would have gone down and that would have been the end of it, but the beam was closer and seemed safer. Three rungs from the top the whine of pulling nails grew louder and I was suddenly cold with terror, with the certainty that I had pushed it too far. The fun of the game was gone.

I hurried out over the hay and dropped off. I came out to the middle of the barn to see Kitty hurrying up the ladder. I called: "Hey, come down! It's not safe!"

KITTY: It'll hold me. I'm lighter than you!

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LARRY: Kitty! . . . But that never got finished. Because that was when the ladder let go. It went with a rotted, splintering crack. I cried out and Kitty screamed. The rung she was standing on gave way, and then both sides of the ladder split. Then it toppled, hitting the barn floor with a flat clap.

Kitty uttered a high, piercing scream. "Larry! Larry! Help me" I knew what had to be done, I saw right away. I was terribly afraid, but not quite scared out of my wits. She was better than sixty feet above me, her blue-jeaned legs kicking wildly at the blank air. I was scared, all right. I knew what had to be done. *(to Kitty)* Kitty! Just hold still, hold still . . .

She obeyed me instantly. Her legs. stopped kicking and she hung straight down, her small hands clutching the last rung on the ragged end of the ladder like an acrobat whose trapeze has stopped.

I ran to the haymow, clutched up a double handful of the stuff, ran back, and dropped it. I went back again. And again. And again. I ran back and forth, building a haystack where the foot of the ladder had been. It was a very small haystack. Back and forth. Back and forth.

KITTY: Larry, I can't hold on much longer!

LARRY: Back and forth. Back and forth. The haystack was as high as my chin now, but the haymow we had been diving into was twenty-five feet deep. I thought that if she only broke her legs it would be getting off cheap. And I knew if she missed the hay altogether, she would be killed. Back and forth.

I could hear the steady, rasping cry of the rung pulling free under her weight. Her legs began to kick again in panic, but if she was thrashing like that, she would surely miss the hay. *(to Kitty)* No! Stop that! Just let go! Let go, Kitty! *(to audience)* Because it was too late for me to get any more hay. Too late for anything except blind hope.

She let go and dropped the second I told her to. She came straight down like a knife. It seemed to me that she dropped forever, her gold pigtails standing straight up from her head, her eyes shut. She didn't scream. Her hands were locked in front of her lips, as if she was

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praying.

And she struck the hay right in the center. She went down out of sight in it- and I heard the thump of her body hitting the boards. It had been too loud, much too loud. But I had to see.

Starting to cry, I pounced on the haystack and pulled it apart. A blue-jeaned leg came to light, then a plaid shirt . . . and then Kitty's face. It was deadly pale, and her eyes were shut. She was dead. I knew it as I looked at her. The world went gray for me, November gray. And then she opened her eyes. "Kitty? Kitty?"

I picked her out of the hay and hugged her and she put her arms around my neck and hugged me back. "You're alive, you're alive, you're alive."

They let me in to see her just before bedtime. She looked at me so long and so lovingly that I was uncomfortable. Then she said,

KITTY: Hay. You put down hay. I didn't know what you were doing, I didn't dare look down, I was too scared. I had my eyes shut the whole time.

LARRY: You didn't know? Didn't know what I was doing? And when I told you to let go you . . . you just did it? Kitty, how could you do that?

She looked at me with those deep blue eyes.

KITTY: I knew you must have been doing something to fix it, You're my big brother. I knew you'd take care of me.

LARRY: It was the end, but somehow not the end. Somehow it never ended until nine days ago, when Kitty jumped from the top story of an insurance building in Los Angeles. I have the clipping from The LA. Times in my wallet. The headline reads: CALL GIRL SWAN-DIVES TO HER DEATH.

We grew up. That's all I know, other than facts that don't mean anything. The only things that matter are that we grew up and she swanned from that insurance building, and that Kitty was the one who always believed the hay would be there. Kitty was the one who had said, "I knew

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you must be doing something to fix it." Those things matter. And Kitty's letter. (reading) Dear Larry, I've been thinking about it a lot lately . . . and what I've decided is that it would have been better for me if that last rung had broken before you could put down the hay. Your, Kitty

She was the one who always knew the hay would be there. And I wasn't.

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AWARD HISTORY

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